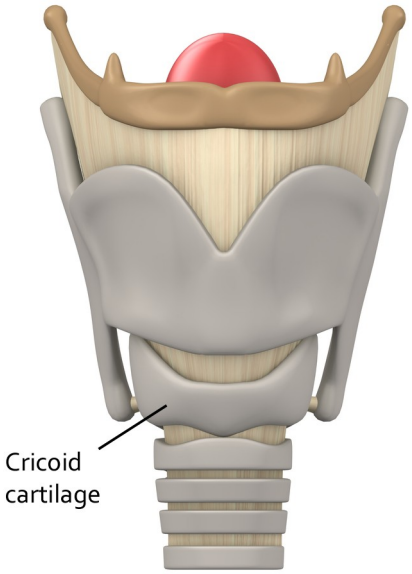
The Sellick maneuver is named for the British anesthetist Brian Arthur Sellick (1918–1996) who first described, in 1961, the procedure of compressing the esophagus by pressing downward on the cricoid cartilage using the thumb and forefinger to prevent aspiration during induction of anesthesia.

When applying the Sellick maneuver, it is recommended that about 9-10 pounds of pressure be applied to the cricoid cartilage. Some practitioner's estimate this amount of pressure as the minimum amount that one could apply to the bridge of the nose to cause pain.



Another more practical method that has been proposed is the BURP method, in which Backward, Upward, and Rightward Pressure is applied to the cricoid cartilage with the thumb and forefinger with enough force to blanch the fingers. Because the esophagus is position just to the right of the trachea in approximately 75% of patients, this method of displacing the cricoid cartilage should be more effective in occluding the esophagus.

Pressure should be maintained on the cricoid cartilage until the position of the endotracheal tube has been verified.

Nagelhout JJ, Plaus K. Nurse Anesthesia. 5th ed. St. Louis, MO: Elsevier Saunders Company; 2014: 448-449.

Copyright 2015 Prodigy Anesthesia, Inc. It is unlawful to copy, distribute, and/or sell this material.